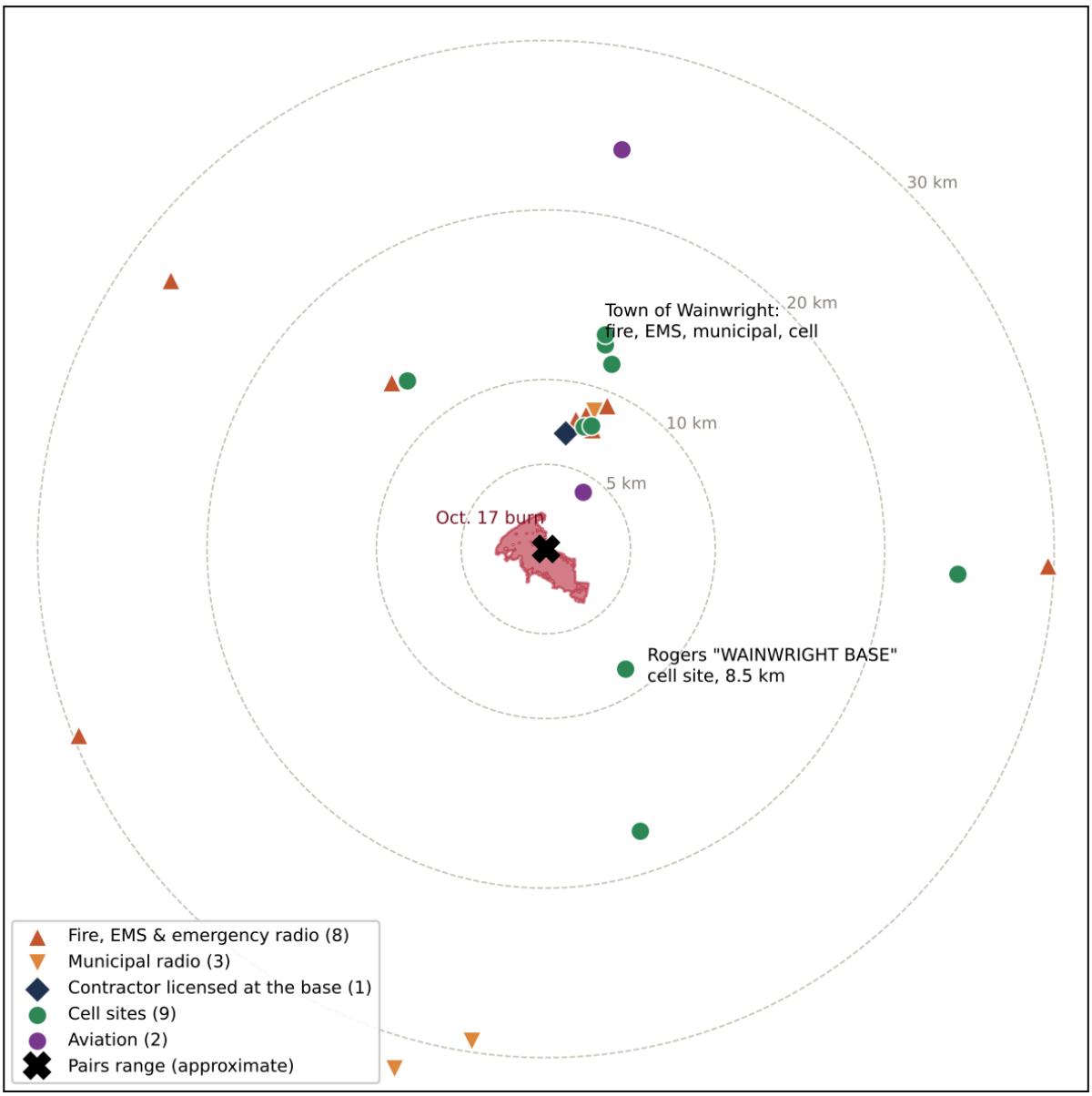
Who could talk to whom: the licensed radio around CFB Wainwright, compared with five other Army training areas

Kevin J.S. Duska Jr. · Oct. 29, 2026

When the wind turned on the afternoon of Oct. 17, the people who needed to know were spread across Range Control, the units on the ranges, the base fire hall, town fire crews, EMS and the aircraft overhead. Who could talk to whom, and on what system, is part of the story of that afternoon. I went through Canada's public radio-licence records to see what they can and can't tell us about CFB Wainwright, and how it compares with other Army training areas.

Bottom line

- **The public record is silent on the military side.** Range Control, the exercise radio nets and the base airfield don't appear in Canada's radio-licence database. That's not unique to Wainwright: I found no Department of National Defence radio licences at Gagetown, Petawawa, Valcartier or Shilo either. The only DND licences are microwave links for exercise control at Wainwright and Suffield, the two Alberta live-fire centres.
- **Alberta's first-responder radio system doesn't appear either.** AFRRCS is the province-wide network that wildfire crews, EMS and many fire departments use, and it isn't listed in the public extract. New Brunswick's provincial system doesn't appear by name either. Whether the base could talk to provincial responders directly has to come from DND and the provinces.
- **Local responders around Wainwright run their own radio systems.** The Town of Wainwright fire department, the Highway 12 Regional Emergency Communications Group, Alberta Health Services EMS, the municipal districts and the nearby village fire halls each hold their own licences. Working with the base on Oct. 17 would have depended on shared channels, radios lent between agencies or a phone call.
- **Phones probably worked on the range.** A Rogers cell site named "WAINWRIGHT BASE" stands 8.5 km from the pairs range on a 104 m structure with low-band LTE. TELUS has sites about 8 km away in town. I haven't modelled terrain, so this is likely, not confirmed.
- **Wainwright isn't an outlier.** Its civilian radio and cell coverage sits in the middle of the six training areas I compared.



Source: ISED Spectrum Management System licence data (Oct. 5, 2026). Burn outline: Prime Rogue. Military radio is not in the public data and is not shown.

Licensed civilian radio within about 30 km of the Oct. 17 burn. The three DND microwave sites are left off the map; military radio isn't in the public data at all.

What I looked at

Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada (ISED) publishes every radio licence it issues: two-way radio, point-to-point links, aviation, and the sites behind cell networks. I used the extracts dated Oct. 5, 2026, twelve days before the fire. I counted licensed stations within 80 km of the pairs range for the Wainwright picture, and within 30 km of each site for the comparison.

Within 80 km of the pairs range there are **597 licensed stations held by 224 licensees**: 393 two-way radio, 196 point-to-point links and 8 aviation. Most belong to farms, pipelines, utilities and municipalities.

Wainwright: what the licences show

Who	What they're licensed for	Distance from the pairs range
Department of National Defence	Three microwave link sites on the base, one labelled "Excon" (exercise control). No two-way radio or aviation licences.	5.5–18.6 km
Falcon Security Co.	One digital UHF channel at "CFB Wainwright". It's the only two-way radio licence at the base itself.	7 km
Town of Wainwright Fire Dept and Public Works	VHF and digital UHF, three sites	7.6–13.4 km
Highway 12 Regional Emergency Communications Group	Digital VHF, sites in Wainwright and at Nose Hill	7.9 km
Alberta Health Services (EMS)	Digital UHF	8.3 km
M.D. of Wainwright; M.D. of Provost	Municipal VHF/UHF	8.6–34 km
Irma, Edgerton and Flagstaff Regional fire services	Fire-hall radio	27–30 km
Wainwright municipal airport; a NAV CANADA navigation aid	Aviation (122.8 MHz at the airport)	4 km; 24 km
Environment Canada Weatheradio, Flagstaff	Weather and warning broadcasts on 162.400 MHz	49 km
Rogers/Fido, TELUS, Xplore	Cell and fixed-wireless sites; the nearest is Rogers' "WAINWRIGHT BASE"	7.6–8.5 km

How Wainwright compares

I ran the same count within 30 km of five other training areas. For Wainwright and Gagetown I used the fire sites. For the other four I used approximate training-area centres I chose myself. Valcartier and Shilo also pick up nearby cities, so read this as a rough comparison, not a ranking.

Training area	DND licences	Contractors licensed at the base	Public-safety radio stations	Nearest cell site	Nearest Weatheradio
Wainwright (fire site)	3 microwave sites, incl. "Excon"	1 (security)	7	7.6 km	49 km
Gagetown (Oct. 28 fire site)	none	none (a university research licence and a Bell link are labelled "CFB Gagetown")	1	8–9 km	33 km
Suffield (approx.)	1 microwave site ("Excon tower")	14 (mostly drone and target testing)	2 (both contractors)	28 km	35 km
Petawawa (approx.)	none	none	13	1.8 km	52 km
Valcartier (approx.)	none	none	2	about 4 km	12 km
Shilo (approx.)	none	none	4	2.1 km	28 km

- **The military side is missing everywhere.** DND doesn't license its tactical and range radio with ISED, so the public record can't show how any of these bases talk to the outside world. The two "Excon" links at Wainwright and Suffield are the only trace.
- **Wainwright and Gagetown are both thin.** Each fire site has only a handful of licensed public-safety stations nearby, and in both provinces the provincial responder network is missing from the public data.
- **Suffield is a different kind of range.** Many private firms are licensed on it, mostly drone and target-system testers, and cell service near its centre is sparse.
- **Weatheradio is a long way off at Wainwright.** The nearest transmitter is 49 km away, one of the two farthest of the six with Petawawa. Weatheradio can sound an alert on receivers built for it, so whether its signal reaches the Wainwright ranges matters for how warnings could get through.

What I can't say yet

- Which radio nets Range Control, the base fire service and the units on the pairs range were using, and whether any of them connected to town fire, EMS or the province.
- Whether CFB Wainwright is a member agency on AFRRCS.
- What frequency and controller the search-and-rescue aircraft and air ambulances used over the training area.
- Whether Environment Canada's 2:14 p.m. wind warning went out on Weatheradio with an alert tone, and whether that signal reaches the base.

I'm putting these questions to DND, the Alberta government (which runs AFRRCS), Environment Canada and NAV CANADA. DND's radio logs and recordings from Oct. 17 are also part of my access-to-information request.

Method and limits

The data is ISED's Spectrum Management System extracts dated Oct. 5, 2026: land mobile, aeronautical and fixed service, plus spectrum-licence site data. It shows licences on that date, a close but not certain proxy for Oct. 17. Stations were grouped by licensee and location. "Public-safety radio stations" means two-way radio licences held by fire, EMS, police or emergency-management bodies. The comparison centres for Suffield, Petawawa, Valcartier and Shilo are approximate. Cell coverage was not modelled. I've left the frequencies and exact positions of DND's links out of this report.

Sources

- ISED, Spectrum Management System data downloads (extracts dated Oct. 5, 2026)
- ISED, licence-list (TAFL) field descriptions

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